

My Session Notes

NSS Interview Skills Workshop — Trade-off Analysis & Stakeholder Communication

What This Session Was Actually About

I've been getting this wrong for a while, and I think I finally understand why. The hardest part of a technical interview isn't having the right answer it's being able to explain a trade-off clearly to someone who doesn't think in systems the way you do. That's what this whole session came down to.

The March 2026 data made it pretty hard to ignore: trade-off analysis was the lowest-scoring section across every single track. And it wasn't that people didn't know the options they did. The gap was in how they communicated. Three things kept showing up:

- Jumping straight to one option without walking through both first
- Using technical language that the other person couldn't actually do anything with
- Making a recommendation so hedged it didn't really mean anything

Those are my habits too. I recognised all three of them.

The Shift I Have to Make

The reframe that landed hardest: trade-off analysis isn't about picking the right answer. It's about helping someone else make an informed decision. That one change in how I think about it reshapes how I structure everything that follows.

What I used to do	What I should do instead
Jump to my preferred option first	Name both options before showing any preference
Explain things in technical terms	Use plain language the client can actually act on
Downplay the costs of my preferred choice	Be honest about what both options cost, including my preferred one
Give a vague or hedged recommendation	Give a clear recommendation tied to their actual situation
Leave them feeling like I made the decision	End by putting the decision back in their hands

The Five-Step Framework

This is the structure I'm committing to apply every time a trade-off question comes up. Don't skip steps. Don't let my preference show until Step 4 that's the rule.

Step 1: Name Both Options

Before I say anything else: "You have two options." Name them both. If I lead with my preferred one, the other option never really gets a fair hearing I've watched myself do this and the client mentally checks out. That stops here.

Step 2: Explain What Each One Gives

What does each option actually give the client? Not the technical specs what do they gain from

it? This is the step where I have to slow down and genuinely think from their perspective, not mine. What matters to them? What problem are they trying to solve?

Step 3: Explain What Each One Costs

Be honest about the downside of both options, including the one I'd actually recommend. Hiding the cost of my preferred choice doesn't help anyone the interviewer will notice it, and it destroys trust. Both sides of every trade-off go on the table.

Step 4: Make My Recommendation With a Reason

Now I can say what I'd go with. But the reason has to come from something they've told me about their situation not "it's more modern" or "I just prefer it." Tie it back to their actual constraints. That's what makes a recommendation credible.

Step 5: Hand the Decision Back

Close with a specific question that puts them in control. Something like: "Which matters more to you right now speed of delivery, or long-term flexibility?" Not a generic "What do you think?" that's too easy to dodge. Give them something concrete to weigh up.

Holding My Ground When Pushed Back

This one's personal. I know I fold under pressure. When a client pushes back on my recommendation, my instinct is to immediately start backtracking and this session called that out directly.

What I do now (collapse)	What I should do (hold the reasoning)
Client: "Are you sure? That seems expensive."	Client: "Are you sure? That seems expensive."
Me: "You're right, actually the other option is probably fine. I don't have a strong preference. Whatever works for you."	Me: "That's a fair concern the upfront cost is higher. But given the scale you described, the alternative would likely cost more in developer time within six months. I still recommend this path. If budget is a hard constraint right now, we could look at a phased approach."
No backbone. The recommendation meant nothing.	Acknowledged the concern. Kept the reasoning. Offered a middle ground.

The second version does three things the first one doesn't: it acknowledges the concern, it keeps the reasoning intact, and it offers a middle ground without abandoning the recommendation entirely. That's the target.

My Quick Reminder Card

Sticking this somewhere visible before interviews.

Name both. Cost both. Recommend with reason. Hand it back.

Step	What it means in practice
01 Name Both Options	"You have two options..." — say this before anything else
02 What Each Gives	Plain language. What does the client actually gain?
03 What Each Costs	Be honest. Both options. Including the one I prefer.
04 Recommend With Reason	Tie it to their situation, not my preference
05 Hand It Back	A specific closing question. Put them in control.